Unit -4

The Delhi Sultanate



Learning Objectives

To acquaint ourselves with

- Turkish Sultans of various dynasties who ruled India from Delhi
- Their military conquests and extension of sovereignty
- Administration of the Delhi Sultanate
- Art and architecture of this period

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Introduction

During the eleventh century, the Turkish horsemen pillaged northern India and due to their persistent campaigns, they succeeded in seizing political control of the Gangetic plain by the next century. Though the success of their conquests could be attributed to their audacity and ferocity, their success is really due to the failure of Indians to defend themselves and their territories. Indians viewed each other with distrust, failing to take note of the success of Islam in early years of its spread. The superior military might of Muslim soldiers was yet another factor that contributed to success in their conquests. In this lesson, we discuss how Turkish warriors set about founding and consolidating their Islamic rule till the advent of Babur.

Mamluk Dynasty (1206 - 1290)

Muslim rule in India was established by Muhammad Ghori in 12th century A.D. (CE). As he had no sons, he nurtured special slaves called *bandagan* (a Persian term used for slaves purchased for military service). These slaves were posted as governors and they were later raised to the status of Sultans. After Ghori's death in 1206, one of his slaves Qutb-ud-din-Aibak who had been left behind by Muhammad Ghori to govern the territories he had conqured, proclaimed himself ruler of the Turkish territories in India. He laid the foundation of the Slave Dynasty. This dynasty is also known as Mamluk dynasty. Mamluk is an Arabic word meaning "slave". Qutb-ud-din-Aibak, Shams-ud-din-Iltutmish and Ghiyas-ud-din-Balban were the three great

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